for such an invasion in historical sources, only the evidence that control of Ikshvaku lands passed after them to the Pallavas, who had been aggressively expanding.

The second and a more plausible theory advanced by ASI archaeologists claims that ‘the mortal blow to the Ikshvaku civic life in Vijayapuri was dealt by the river’, whose levels had risen steadily over sixty to seventy years, causing more frequent flooding and silt deposits evident in the excavated strata. The Ikshvakus had recognized the problem and had started building flood-control measures, including embankments and raising the floor height of riverside temples. In the city’s last twenty years of habitation, however, the river levels rose a whopping nine feet, submerging much of the ghat. A major jolt perhaps came around the start of the last king’s reign, when the raging river flooded the citadel and the western half of the city, forcing people there to migrate to the eastern part, where life apparently continued for many years. This massive disruption likely led to a slow evacuation and perhaps made it easier for the Pallavas to defeat Vijayapuri.

What’s amply clear is that Vijayapuri declined rapidly and no Ikshvaku records were found after 310 CE. By 320 CE or so, notes ASI, ‘political stability in the valley and secular amenities had all declined severely’ and most of its population likely moved to greener pastures. We can only speculate what life felt like during this period of intense upheaval. The valley soon ‘became a moribund museum of the Ikshvaku heritage of standing monuments’,[33] a sad end to a wonderful and mostly peaceful century of intellectual ferment and artistic creativity.

The Remains of the Day

Nowadays, most visitors to Nagarjunakonda Island come for the scenic ferry ride and picnic with family or friends under a shady tree on the lawns. The Ikshvakus never seemed to have lived, or at least built structures, on this hill, now covered with cactus, low brush and a few trees, including Bodhi trees (‘ficus religiosa’). The 3–4-km walk to the transplanted and partially restored ruins of the Great Stupa, temples, monasteries, pillars, stupas, bathing/ritual tanks and a megalithic tomb makes a pleasant and